warmth, and conversed with them at length, before sending them to their quarters under the charge of Abu'l Fazl and Hakim Ali Geelani.

The following day the priests presented to Akbar in the diwane-khas the *Royal Polyglot Bible*, beautifully bound in seven volumes and containing illustrations engraved by Flemish artists and recently printed in Antwerp. Each volume had a phantasmagorical painting in an anatomically accurate and naturalistic style that would profoundly influence the future course of Mughal art. Akbar respectfully took off his turban and placed each volume on his head before kissing it. He then had the books sent to his private room and, leading Acquaviva by the hand, took the Jesuit to show him the casket he had had made specially for the holy books.

One can well imagine the great turmoil in Acquaviva's heart during these meetings—the culmination of a lifetime of ardent prayers and hopes. This was a man, twenty-nine years old now, who had spent his life in a self-imposed 'rule of silence and solitude, only coming out of his cell for purposes of religion'. He preferred to wear worn-out garments and shoes and when going about his work 'used to take pleasure in singing softly to (the Virgin Mary's) honour little extempore songs which he improvised'. He was also deeply virginal, in effect and in manner, 'devoted to perpetual chastity and invoked the aid of the Virgin Mother of God to enable him to keep this resolution'. This man, trailing faintly around him the musky, ecclesiastical odour of daily scourgings, of dried blood, of abstinence and denial, now came into the presence of Akbar, thirty-eight years old, and in the full splendour of his life and personality. A man 'sturdy, hearty and robust…exceedingly well-built and…neither too thin nor too stout' with eyes 'so bright and flashing that they seem like a sea shimmering in the sunlight'; a man who tamed cheetahs for pleasure and who invoked the love of God by facing down tigers and riding wild elephants; a monarch who unselfconsciously led his visitor by the hand in his eagerness, radiating human warmth, and hospitality while for Acquaviva all physicality was a reminder of the loathsome weakness of the flesh, to be overcome by pain and repentance and constant deprivation.

In Akbar's quarters the air would have been perfumed by the scent of his favourite ambergris, perhaps, incense burning in gold censers, and masses of fresh-cut fragrant nargis and champa. There would have been soft carpets underfoot and beautiful vases and images in every niche in the walls. About Acquaviva, Monserrate noted that 'he was of virgin modesty.